

■ By Muhammad Najeeb in Islamabad

Troubles now seem to come in bagfuls for Pakistan President General Pervez Musharraf. Even as the controversy over the suspension of Pakistan's chief justice by his government continues to erode his image, he is now pitted against another powerful political class: the mullahs. In a move that is widely seen as a diversionary to his woes on the judicial front, Musharraf ordered Rangers to encircle the Lal Masjid in the heart of the capital, and flush out militants holed up in the complex who had become a law unto themselves. In the deadly standoff, 22 people including three security personnel have already been killed and scores injured as the Government even employed helicopter gunships and armoured personnel carriers to pressurise the militants into leaving the complex.

By the end of the second day the army made some headway when

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TAKING ON THE MULLAHS

By using military might to flush out militants holed up in Islamabad's Lal Masjid, the beleaguered Pervez Musharraf tries to shore up his eroding credibility. But his battling radicals may backfire.

Maulana Abdul Aziz, the radical chief priest of the Masjid, was arrested while he was trying to sneak away wearing a burqa. Hours after the Maulana's arrest, his brother, Abdul Rashid Ghazi, who was still holed up in the complex, told INDIA TODAY, "I never thought that our own people will leave us and the Government would launch such a deadly operation against us."

Ghazi, who before the stand-off claimed that more than 100 suicide bombers were ready to attack government installations and public places if any operation was launched against the Lal Masjid, sounded demoralised. On the third day, over 2,000 of the Masjid's student activists had surrendered, taking up the government's offer of Rs 5,000 and a pardon. For the girls, there was a promise of having their education fully paid for. There were indications that the others holed up in the complex might surrender as

the Government seemed determined to flush them out at whatever the cost.

Ironically, instead of being lauded for taking tough action against Islamic radicals, the Masjid flush-out was regarded as late in coming and done only when Musharraf's hand was forced. The Lal Masjid is one of the more prominent of Islamabad's mosques. It is also adjacent to a religious school for girls, the Jamia Hafsa, that has about 4,000 students, of which about 3,000 live inside the multi-storey building that has been constructed on government land without permission. About three km away is the Jamia Faridia, the boys section with about 5,000 students run by the Lal Masjid.

Throughout most of its existence, the masjid has long been favoured by the city elite, including prime ministers, army chiefs and presidents. The Lal Masjid and Jamia Hafsa were in the news in July 2005 when Pakistani

security forces tried to raid the masjid following the suicide bombings that month in London. The security personnel were met by baton-wielding women who refused to let them enter the masjid or the school compound. Authorities said the security forces were investigating a link between the seminary and Shehzad Tanweer, one of the July 7 bombers.

For the past six months, the militant occupants of the Lal Masjid were in the public eye for using its premises to carry out propaganda in support of the Taliban and also behaving as the citizen's moral police. It began when Maulana Aziz claimed that he had experienced "sacred dreams"—numbering 300 till the last count—in which, according to him, Prophet Mohammad personally ordered him to raise the standard of revolt, declare jihad and implement the Shariah (Islamic laws) on his own. The maulana